Hangman

By William Borden

THEODORE: Don't you feel some dishonesty? Killing people you have so much in common with?

ROGER: I don't find it dishonest, no. Poignant, perhaps. Ironic. Tragic, even. It's like playing a part in a great drama. It fulfills me. Whereas you become nameless, faceless, one of many who die futilely.

INTRODUCTION

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(THEODORE, watched by ROGER, stands on a stool, tying a rope to a pipe or beam. He finishes and steps off the stool. They both appraise it/or a moment, then ROGER tugs at the rope. The rope comes off ROGER throws the rope to THEODORE.)

ROGER: You think I haven't seen everything? Every trick and ruse you scum could possibly think of? You think I'm not smart?

THEODORE: You're very smart.

ROGER: I am.

THEODORE: I imagine you have a Ph.D.

ROGER: Don't get smart with me. *(THEODORE ties the rope again.)*

THEODORE: This will be a foolproof knot. Guaranteed to kill instantly.

ROGER: Not instantly. We want you to ponder your ways, reflect on your errors, as you dangle, swaying slowly in the breeze. Then we allow you to expire.

THEODORE: Expire.

ROGER: Yes.

THEODORE: You have an enormous vocabulary.

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ROGER: Thank you.

THEODORE: A veritable prodigious lexicon in your cerebrum.

ROGER: I read vociferously. No television, no card games – I have the complete collection of The Great Books.

THEODORE: The Great Books? Who wrote them?

ROGER: You know those guys, from Homer and the Bible to Melville and Prowst.

THEODORE: Prowst?

ROGER: You're not too well read yourself, are you?

THEODORE: No, I'm not.

ROGER: Prowst was a French guy, wrote in a cork-lined room, suffered from asthma. He pursued the nuances of the past. Cherchez the past. And he was a fag. *(ROGER tests the beam.)* That's better.

THEODORE: Might be too sturdy.

ROGER: Naw.

THEODORE: I might not dangle long enough. I have a lot of sins to reflect upon as I die.

ROGER: They go fast. Whole life in a flash. That's the rumor.

THEODORE: As I dangle.

ROGER: As you dangle.

THEODORE: In the breeze.

ROGER: In the breeze.

THEODORE: What breeze? We're indoors. Miles from daylight. So you've told me.

ROGER: Well, just the momentum, as you plunge through the opening, and the rope, you know, jerks you up, as you're plunging down - gives your body what they call a torque, an angular momentum, so your body, as it's expiring, will swing, from its own potential energy.

THEODORE: Torque.

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ROGER: You'll sway in quite graceful circles, or possibly ellipses, around and around.

THEODORE: Like a pendulum.

ROGER: *Exactement.*

THEODORE: I could become a clock.

ROGER: If I left you there.

THEODORE: Then you were lying about the breeze.

ROGER: It was a bit of poetry.

THEODORE: Do you write?

ROGER: Reports?

THEODORE: Poetry.

ROGER: Me?

THEODORE: Let me hear something.

ROGER: Naw...

THEODORE: Please! *(ROGER pulls out a fat sheaf of scraps of paper. Then he looks at THEODORE.)*

ROGER: You'll laugh. *(THEODORE doesn't answer. ROGER hesitates, then starts to read.)* "The rope sings like a nightingale as it snaps across the breeze" Maybe breeze isn't right there. *(ROGER takes out a pencil.)* "The rope sings like a nightingale as it snaps ... into the ... abyss ... of death."

THEODORE: "Death" 's trite.

ROGER: You're right. "Abyss of ... "

THEODORE: "Like a raven." "Raven" 's better than "nightingale." "Raven" connotes the harshness of the moment.

ROGER: It's a beautiful moment. Lyrical. And for those who disagree, there's the irony, the poignant reversal of expectation. "Abyss of ... "

THEODORE: "Horror."

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ROGER: "Abyss of ... "

THEODORE: "Meaninglessness." "Nothingness." "Darkness."

ROGER: "Into the abyss of..."

THEODORE: "... into the sweet memory of roses." *(ROGER looks at him a moment, then writes it down, shoves packet into his pocket.)*

ROGER: *(Reluctantly)* Thanks. *(ROGER tests the knot. It holds.)* Good work.

THEODORE: Thanks.

ROGER: Of course it's not a professional job.

THEODORE: I'm going to hang!

ROGER: I'd think that would be a particular reason for taking pride in your work. Here. *(ROGER hands THEODORE the other end of the rope.)*

THEODORE: Now what?

ROGER: The noose. Make the noose.

THEODORE: *(Throwing down the rope)* No. I won't participate any further in my own murder.

ROGER: Execution, my friend. Words are important.

THEODORE: Shoot me then! That will make it murder!

ROGER: However I do it, it's an execution.

THEODORE: No

ROGER: I'm the executioner. It's a matter of definition. The man who writes the dictionary rules the nation. I can execute you now - *(He pulls out the pistol.)* Or you can have another minute or two to enjoy God's bounty on earth, while you tie the rope, while I test it, while we engage in scintillating dialect. Which do you prefer?

THEODORE: Shoot me. We might as well get it over with.

ROGER: That seems mighty shortsighted, my friend. Who knows what might occur in the next ninety seconds? An earthquake might kill me and free you.

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The rebels might stage an attack and divert my attention, allowing you to escape. There might be a coup from above. A foreign invasion. The Commander might commit suicide. You might receive a pardon. Don't forget - what's his name? You know, the Russian

THEODORE: Dostoevsky?

ROGER: That's the guy. Life is ruled by chance, old boy. Ninety seconds can seem like an eternity.

THEODORE: Everything is fated.

ROGER: An Augustinian!

THEODORE: There is a destiny

ROGER: God's? Or the inevitability of historical materialism? *(THEODORE doesn't answer.)*

THEODORE: I think for me ninety seconds will pass quickly.

ROGER: Time is relative.

THEODORE: Time marches forward inexorably.

ROGER: Inexorably.

THEODORE: Inexorably. I relish intellectual debate. Don't you? I haven't had a good discussion for a hell of a long time.

ROGER: *(ROGER hands the rope again to THEODORE.)* The noose.

THEODORE: I don't know how.

ROGER: I don't believe it.

THEODORE: It's not something you need to know in the normal course of a lifetime. *(Disgusted, ROGER begins to make the noose.)*

ROGER: The other executioners, you know, all they want to do is play cards, read girlie magazines. I'm out of my element.

THEODORE: I can see that. *(He watches ROGER deftly make the noose.)* You're very good.

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ROGER: Funny thing is, you guys usually have something to talk about. You seem to think more. It must be thinking that makes you dissatisfied with things.

THEODORE: It's not only thinking.

ROGER: I suppose not.

THEODORE: It's feeling, too. You know, intuitively, things aren't right.

ROGER: Well, it depends which side you're on, doesn't it? Like for me, things are right. *(He completes the noose. He admires his work.)*

THEODORE: But they're not.

ROGER: Of course they're right. Right as rain.

THEODORE: You're not happy.

ROGER: *(Angrily)* I'm happy!

THEODORE: You're a fish out of water. No intellectual companionship. No one to share ideas with.

ROGER: *(Slipping the noose over THEODORE's head)* Now there's where you're wrong, old sport. I have you to converse with. You and your compatriots. All day, every day, one after another, a veritable parade of intellect.

THEODORE: Perhaps you'd like to join us.

ROGER: Get myself executed?

THEODORE: Fight for a cause.

ROGER: Die before my time?

THEODORE: Live a meaningful life.

ROGER: Die like a dog? There's a flaw in your syllogism. *(ROGER motions THEODORE onto the stool.)*

THEODORE: Don't you feel some dishonesty? Killing people you have so much in common with?

ROGER: I don't find it dishonest, no. Poignant, perhaps. Ironic. Tragic, even. It's like playing a part in a great drama. It fulfills me. Whereas you become

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nameless, faceless, one of many who die futilely.

THEODORE: Who knows what's futile?

ROGER: It's plain as the noose around your neck.

THEODORE: But don't we have some effect? Make some difference?

ROGER: Oh, yeah. I learn a lot. I sharpen my wits. You make a big difference to me.

THEODORE: Do I?

ROGER: Definitely. *(THEODORE climbs onto the stool.)*

THEODORE: I mean, do *I?* Do I, Theodore, make a difference to you?

ROGER: What do you mean?

THEODORE: Or am I just one of many who pass through your life? What's your name?

ROGER: My name? I have no name. So far as you're concerned.

THEODORE: Have you no conscience?

ROGER: Do you? Wouldn't you kill me if you could? Even after our thrilling conversation? You would. Because I'm on the other side. It would be my fate to die.

THEODORE: It would be a chance you would take.

ROGER: So you see, I have no choice.

THEODORE: You always have a choice.

ROGER: Do you? *(ROGER gets ready to kick away the stool.)*

THEODORE: One question - *(ROGER pauses.)* Does everyone participate in his own ... death?

ROGER: Oh, yes. We think it makes a point. It teaches a lesson.

THEODORE: But what good will it do now?

ROGER: That's the irony of it, isn't it? Any further last words?*(Several beats. ROGER gets ready to kick away the stool.)*

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THEODORE: Proost.

ROGER: What?

THEODORE: Proost! It's pronounced Proost, not Prowst!

ROGER: You kidding me?

THEODORE: No.

ROGER: You're sure?

THEODORE: I'm positive.

ROGER: You know French?

THEODORE: *Tres bien.*

ROGER: Proost.

THEODORE: Proost.

ROGER: I could've gone on for years making a fool of myself.

THEODORE: I know. *(Several beats)*

ROGER: Well. We can't wait forever.

THEODORE: No. *(Several beats)*

ROGER: Roger.

THEODORE: Pardon?

ROGER: My name's Roger.

THEODORE: Ah. *(Beat)* Theodore.

ROGER: Right. *(ROGER starts to kick away the stool, the stage goes to black, and there s a strange musical note, as of a string being plucked, the overtone lasting for several seconds.)*

The rope sings
like a nightingale
as it snaps
into the sweet
memory of roses.

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It's a beautiful moment. Lyrical.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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